



BEFORE

By early 1865, the plight of Robert E. Lee's Army of Northern Virginia was becoming increasingly desperate. If it was defeated, the Confederate capital would fall.

OTHER CONFEDERATE ARMIES

Late 1864 saw a **succession of Southern defeats** throughout Georgia and Tennessee. General William T. Sherman concluded his devastating [March to the Sea](#) with the **capture of Savannah**. Meanwhile, General John Bell Hood's **invasion of Tennessee** was smashed at [Nashville](#).

LENGTHENING ODDS

Immobilized in the trenches outside Petersburg (see [The Siege of Petersburg](#)) since June 1864, the Confederate force confronted a **numerically stronger, better-supplied enemy**. With the odds lengthening week by week, Lee's only recourse lay in bold action. But the chances of success were never good.

As 1865 dawned, the opposing armies dug in outside Petersburg were stymied. In a campaign that foreshadowed the trench warfare of World War I, both sides had made repeated attempts to achieve a breakthrough without gaining any decisive advantage.

Union superiority

Yet the situation was much more serious for Robert E. Lee's army than it was for Ulysses S. Grant's. The Southern army was outnumbered by more than two to one, and the odds were worsening week by week as a steady stream of desertions further sapped its manpower. Grant had been able to use his numerical advantage gradually to extend his lines, which stretched Lee's resources to the limits. Moreover, the Confederate supply routes had been cut one by one, with the loss of Wilmington, the only surviving link to the sea, delivering a particularly devastating blow.

With only bad news coming from the Carolinas, Lee knew that it could only be a matter of time before General Sherman's forces would be able to link up with the Army of the Potomac and complete his encirclement. To avoid that scenario, Lee had to extricate his army as soon as possible.

Lee turned to Major General John B. Gordon, commander of the Second Corps, who devised a strategy that involved sending armed troops masquerading as deserters to launch a surprise assault on Fort Stedman, a strongpoint at the eastern end of the Federal lines.